making fifties. At the end of the third day I was not out on 67 in our first innings and playing well. Could I really make that elusive 100th hundred on my home ground?

On our way to the ground on the morning of the fourth day, the number of outside-broadcast vans lined up opposite the stadium was staggering and that's when I realized this was a very different occasion from normal. Darren Sammy, the West Indies captain, took the second new ball and immediately there was some movement for both Fidel Edwards and Ravi Rampaul. I was standing outside the crease to counter the movement and told myself not to chase any balls outside off stump while the ball was swinging. I started the day well by flicking Rampaul for four in the very first over, following it up with a punch off Edwards through cover. I then produced an upper cut over slip for six against Edwards and was just seven short of the hundred.

Just then, I looked at the scoreboard and started to feel distinctly strange. My feet were heavy and it was as if I had no strength left. I had never felt as nervous in my career, not even when I had been about to make my first Test hundred in 1990. I walked away towards square leg and took a few deep breaths. I kept telling myself to concentrate hard and not lose focus. It was a sensation I had never experienced before.

My ninety-fourth run was a single to deep point. In the next over from Rampaul, I played the last three balls after Virat had taken a single off the third delivery. The fourth ball was full and I played it to cover, moving well to the pitch of the ball and negating any possible movement. The next ball bounced a little but I managed to play it down with soft hands. Rampaul was trying to get the ball to move away and I needed to be watchful. The last ball of the over came in to me quicker and bounced a little more than I anticipated and the shot travelled quickly to Sammy at second slip, who held a good catch. It all happened within a fraction of a second and only when I glanced back did I realize that I was out.

The realization was exceedingly painful. I had come within one shot of the century. But you can never take anything for granted in the game, and that's part of its beauty. I was still dazed as I walked back to the pavilion, trying to take in the applause of a very appreciative crowd. The wait would have to continue and the pressure was bound to become even more intense in the days ahead.